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# Jon Jang

*Composer and pianist Jon Jang was born in Los Angeles on March 11, 1954. After attending Oberlin College he settled in San Francisco and was instrumental in raising awareness of Asian-American cultures through his compositions. Jon has recorded his work on the Asian-Improv label which he co-founded in 1987.*

*Jon was interviewed at Hamilton College on September 17, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.*

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are at Hamilton College filming for the Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have pianist and composer Jon Jang with me today, and welcome to Hamilton.

JJ: Well thank you, Monk.

MR: I've overheard some of your conversations with students and you've said some great things. I hope I don't make you repeat yourself too much.

JJ: Oh well I don't even remember, and I don't even remember if they were great so —

MR: All right. I like the way you describe your own music as two flowers and a stem. Can you elaborate on that for me?

JJ: Well yeah. Two flowers on a stem is a metaphor expressing the symbiotic relationship of my cultural identity as a Chinese-American and a way of honoring tradition and encouraging new ideas, new innovation. "Two Flowers on a Stem" is also the name of a work that I composed I think in the early nineties and it's the title track of the Jon Jang sextet on Soul Note Records, which is a company that's based in Milano, Italy and a recording company incidentally that promoted a lot of David Murray's work. And my sextet included David Murray on tenor saxophone and bass clarinet, James Newton on flute, who is my close friend and artist partner that I've collaborated with for twenty years now, Jiebing Chen on erhu, whose — the erhu is a Chinese two stringed instrument and she literally reinvented the erhu. Let's see who else. Santi Debriano, bassist from New Jersey and New York, and of course the great Billy Hart on multiple percussion. So it was an incredible experience. And "Two Flowers on a Stem" features the melody that I wrote for the erhu, and — let's see how can I express it — it expresses the feeling of conflict becoming tenderness as a desire for beauty and strength. And that resulted out of a tragedy that occurred in my family when my father died in the worst plane disaster over the Grand Canyon in 1956. It made the front page of the *New York Times*. And so he was a rising executive. He was going to be a vice president of Ford Corporation and he had overcome racism in Southern California or the United States in the 1950s, because that

was the period of the McCarthy period. And if you were a Chinese-American you were suspicious of being a Communist and so forth. I actually had an FBI investigation, but mainly because he worked for the chemical plants and so he received Q Clearance, which was the highest clearance. But anyway he died in this plane crash in 1956, a two airplane crash. And when my family tried to hold services at the Glendale Cemetery I think — was it in Burbank or Glendale — I was only two years old — they refused us services. Even though my father's body wasn't going to be buried there, because it was burned to ashes in the fire in the plane crash. So we ended up in the Hollywood Hills. So that described the experience to me even though I didn't understand a thing when I was two years old, as kind of what my mother had to go through raising three of us. Because there was two of us before my dad died, and then 8-1/2 months later my sister was born. So it evoked this image of my mother as being a lily that can endure in the swamp of racism. So and I guess that's part of the meaning of "Two Flowers on a Stem."

MR: It's a nice metaphor. It must have been difficult for her to convey what that was like to you once you were old enough to understand it. Is that how you learned about the incident with the cemetery and all that, from her?

JJ: No. I mean she withdrew and even entered depression and suffered a nervous breakdown and it was told actually years later by friends of my father.

MR: Were your parents interested in integrating themselves as much into American culture as they could? Or did they keep their own cultural identity intact?

JJ: Well they both spoke Cantonese, but because they were from different villages they didn't speak together. But my mother, even though she still retains Cantonese at the third grade level, doesn't speak to my daughter, who is in a Chinese immersion program. This was during a period, and still continues today in an English-only environment. And the assimilation process of Chinese-Americans was very distinct than say Japanese Americans in the way that Chinese-Americans or Chinese-Americans that lived in Chinatown, was based more on the immigrant experience and they spoke the language, they ate the food, there is the customs and mannerisms, the Cantonese opera, mahjong. Whereas being removed and living in a predominantly white suburb area, you became American and you spoke only English. And I had no connection with China simply because during the fifties, the McCarthy period, and the 1960s, you couldn't even talk about China. It was taboo until 19, what was it, early seventies when Kissinger and Nixon came to visit to China. That began to loosen. I mean in the public schools I think you could learn the Japanese language, but the Chinese language was not offered. I mean there's Chinese schools I think in San Francisco, Chinatown, you could go there. But if you're in the white suburbs.

MR: Yeah. I have this memory of having a write a report on Communist China in high school and having to get information from the London Embassy, because they didn't have anything in the States here. Interesting how things change.

JJ: Yeah there was only I think one film about China that I remember seeing when I think I was in high school. It was called "Misunderstanding China." And I think it wasn't shown to me yet until the early seventies.

MR: So it was a conscious — well I shouldn't read anything into it — was it a conscious decision on your part then to explore your own culture that you hadn't got in the suburbs?

JJ: Well my mother was living the American dream even though a little shattered by my father's death, but living comfortably in Palo Alto now. She moved to Palo Alto, a quiet white suburb where Stanford University is located. And we had the Leave it to Beaver television, the American dream of having a house, a car. But there were dramatic changes happening in the country. And people were seeking alternative vision. I mean you had in the early sixties the Civil Rights period. And now as we are speaking in the interview it's the 35th anniversary of the Third World student strikes at San Francisco State on November 6, 1968. And that was the longest student strike, it had a profound impact, not only the creation of ethnic studies all over the nation, but I think that you had an explosion of political activists coming from so many different areas. You had not only students but there was women, what we called the oppressed nationalities or Third World people, now I guess we are saying people of color, gay and lesbians, workers. And so there was a counter hegemonic movement. People seeking for new alternatives. And I think it had an impact on our ideology, although it hadn't really changed our economic structures and we can see the result of that today. And so I mean I didn't know anything about my history as a Chinese-American. I didn't know about the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882. I didn't know that the Chinese came over here and they built a railroad. And that wasn't a part included in our history. And I think that all these groups, these ethnic groups, started looking into the history of what our families did. And then not only trying to make it part of like the curriculum and part of people's lives, but also doing things in the community, investing in the communities and making a change in the communities.

MR: That's really interesting. I assume you were an aspiring musician before this kind of activism became known to you?

JJ: No actually I started piano at the age of 19. And I don't like to — I'm only providing a context. Because I wasn't a political activist. It was more like okay here I am in Palo Alto, the white suburbs, and all I see is my block and Leave it to Beaver. This is the reality. Whereas there is all kinds of things that are going around outside my neighborhood. I mean there's East Palo Alto, an African-American area, and then there's what's happening in the world with the Vietnam War and what the United States empire

is doing to other countries. But what was to me a turning point was when my cousin, who is currently an art professor and a friend of mine who is a drummer, introduced to me the music of John Coltrane. And even though I was not politically sophisticated or musically sophisticated at that time, I was only 17 or 18 years old, I was able to see how that music was connected — when I say — see I felt that music was connected with Malcolm X and later on I discovered that Malcolm X and that whole tradition of Harlem street corner oratorical style, Ed Davis, was connected with that music of John Coltrane and Albert Ayler and urban blues, and later on I discovered, even though I felt the connection of Martin Luther King with Gospel music and sermons, as Paul Robeson said, are sermons that are sung. So it was an incredible transformation and that's why I say that that music became just as real to me, and maybe in some ways more important than Malcolm X because it was such on a high political level and I didn't understand it. I mean they were words. I mean you're 18 years old, 17, 18 years old, how are you going to understand it? Coltrane's music, you didn't really need to understand it to recognize its power. And so then I dropped out of UC Berkeley and I guess, oh yeah, the other part of the story is that when I was in high school a Stanford University grad student was teaching, then they called them alternative schools, was teaching in an alternative school class, a history class. And he knew I had some interest in music. So he gave me a book called *Blues People* by Leroi Jones, who is now called Amiri Baraka. And that changed me because the premise of that book is that as African-American people's lives changed their music changed. And so in that book he talks about how Africans were brought over unwillingly to the United States and become slaves, and that they brought their songs over but the difference is that singing a song and working in your own land is different than singing a song working for somebody else's land. So I thought about, and this is when I started thinking about my identity as a Chinese-American. Because there was I think Alex Haley's "Roots" and searching for your roots, and that kind of climate that was popular. And so what happened when the Chinese came to the United States to build a railroad? Did they bring their songs? And did the context change? Now there's no proof of that but that inspired me to write "Great Wall Gold Mountain," which is on Tiananmen Recording, it's the second movement. And it starts off with a Chinese work song that actually was inspired by another Chinese work song that was made I think it was in China, it was a Yen Ching work song, I think it was of the railroad, I can't recall. And part of that work was inspired by Duke Ellington's "Black, Brown and Beige" which he calls a tone parallel to African-American experience or life. And the first movement of that is "The Work Song." And when I heard that music and the music that, this was introduced to me by Professor Wendell Logan. He was professor of African-American studies, jazz studies and contemporary music at the Oberlin Conservatory of Music. And

he served in sort of a mentor role. And so I was exposed to like "Black, Brown and Beige," and a tone parallel to Harlem. And so I began to connect how music was part of life. And so I would say like my music is like an expression of my life. But as an American it means that I'm exposed to a diversity of influences and a younger generation of kids, through Internet, and they have access to a lot of opportunities.

MR: Did your combining of these certain elements, do you run into let's say problem solving situations with scales that might be inherently Chinese and our music here, based on diatonic scales, etc. How do you work those together?

JJ: Well one of the questions I asked is the tuning, western and non-western tuning. And I kind of equate my experience when I used to perform in the joints — I didn't perform in the blues clubs like in Oakland, and that was probably a learning lesson for me both in terms of music, and trying to respect the music, and also socially. Because it's just very atypical for a Chinese-American to be performing in the joints in Oakland, in an African-American club. But when you have like a singer who is bending the pitch, the inflection, you have the variable pitch. You have a guitar that's bending notes. The piano is a fixed pitch instrument but sometimes you have, you can create the illusion by clusters or grace notes and so forth. But that was never ever a problem, having variable pitched and fixed pitch instruments. Where in the Chinese orchestra you have like the erhu, which is a Chinese two stringed instrument which has that inflection bending that can fit right in in the blues. And you have other melodic variable pitch. But in the Chinese orchestra you also have the yanquin, which is a Chinese hammered dulcimer instrument. It's trapezoidal shaped with metal strings across and it's performed with a pair of bamboo sticks. And that's similar to the piano which a hammer or stick is striking metal strings. And that's a fixed pitch instrument. So it's not like you have to think about like you have to be in tune. It creates this beautiful color. And just in a similar way when I listen to Miles Davis and Wayne Shorter, when they're blending but sometimes there's a beauty in that when things are not fitted perfectly.

MR: Yeah. Rough edges.

JJ: But they are really fitted perfectly.

MR: That's great. I've heard some fascinating Chinese music that's basically just percussion and cymbals. Great stuff. Have you adapted any of that kind of —

JJ: Well that's a great question because I find that the future in Chinese music, putting aside Paul Robeson and I agree with him, said that the greatest contribution from China — well he actually said the Orient — but in China, was its melodic development. But there is like what I discovered when I was in Beijing in 1994 and I was there studying Beijing opera percussion or Beijing opera music and I met with a couple of Chinese musicians in the Beijing opera, and one of them was a percussionist, I learned of like some — I was

exposed to some rhythmic organizations. Like they have these four gongs and they're pitched differently. And I don't want to get into the technical aspect of it, but one was like they go [scats beat] and then all of a sudden they go into this what they call the horse leg rhythm or mater. So actually you can visually think of it, so they go [scats beats]. And when I heard that I was performing Charles Mingus' "Meditations on Integration." And they had this rhythm that [scats] and I could hear that melody going over that rhythm and how there was what I would say metric modulation that was going on. You know how Charles Mingus and Ellington, they would switch meters and tempo modulation and all of that. And that's why for me the critical question is, you know it's important to learn what they did and study it. But then for me when I interpret their music, and I'm very selective about that, I say well what if Charles Mingus was alive today. How would he do it? What if he exposed to the Chinese erhu? And that's what's on the "Two Flowers on a Stem" recording, is the erhu replaces the bass which plays the melody of "Meditations on Integration." And then, well anyway, so I made some changes so that that would be featured.

MR: I can imagine David [Murray] in that scenario too. He's got such big ears that I'm sure that that was just really great for him to deal with something new.

JJ: David is, yeah, he's just, I can't say that — he's just on an amazing high level. And just my brief experience of us working together just elevated me on a level. And he's just very generous and patient. And last year I was commissioned by the Rockefeller Multi-Arts Production Fund, the San Francisco Arts Commission and Meet the Composer in New York to compose a work called "Up From the Root" which was to celebrate Chinese-American identity, Chinese diaspora specifically. Because I'd attended a conference where I met Chinese from South Africa, Madagascar. So I wrote a work for David Murray and Melody of China, a Chinese music organization. So that experience is very different than some of my other works with ensembles where you have just one Chinese instrumentalist with a predominantly ensemble of musicians like David and James Newton and Billy Hart. So in this case my approach is Chinese musicians have a tradition. And you allow them to be who they are but you change it so that they get something out of it. You create the structure so they improvise within their own world, but then you allow David to do what he does. So in some ways maybe part of the direction of music is that when you have different cultures, and it's probably more specific to Chinese because it's not, they don't really improvise. And there's not a tradition of collective improvisation. You have them perform their tradition and you put it in a different context. So what you have is a simultaneous existence of two cultures, say they're responding to each other. So there is sort of a transformation that's taking place. So I mean I don't have the music that's recorded here but there was one piece that was

called "Sweet Whisper of a Flower" that I composed. And it has — I hate to use the word influences — but it's from my study of music of Wayne Shorter and Billy Strayhorn in terms of how they use color and timbre. And so what I did was I took a Chinese melody like the "Golden Snake Dance," and put in a different tempo that was more like a ballad impressionistic. And then I wrote a countermelody that had characteristics of a Chinese folk melody but placed in different beats, places, accents, so that it would be more rhythmic variety. Because Chinese music is very simple. It's not — the highest polyrhythmic level is syncopated. It's not like in jazz you have polyrhythmic — you have conflict of rhythms and things going against each other. So I did that. And then another piece we used the "Golden Snake Dance" but we put it over like a bass line that's reminiscent of George Clinton. Because David Murray, he's got that, he's serious funk. So I wrote in that context and they were able to be allowed to be themselves. And they loved it. Because they heard this — they get kind of tired of playing this same old traditional melodies. But then they started putting inflection against this funk line that David was playing. And they enjoyed it. It was beautiful. And then I had a section where they were able to improvise. But I had to like give them music of James Brown and I'm trying to think who else, as much of music that sounded like what we were trying to do so that they can get a context. But one thing, I think it works in that context. But trying to teach Chinese musicians to swing is difficult. It's difficult for me, as an American born, even listening to the music, to learn to swing. Because I mean I did a recording in collaboration with Max Roach. But when they did the music they were doing it, they were creating their music morning, day and night. And then there was social function with dance. And so there is a different context when you're learning it, it's kind of I guess either art form or it's removed. And you're not doing it in a day to day — because well in San Francisco there's not like the either like community centers or clubs or whatever, social context for you to live and breathe it every day.

MR: That defining swing is always a hard thing to do. Are there words that you can use? Or is it more of a trying to show them with your instrument?

JJ: It's like anything, you have to work with it and you have to work with people that do it, and you have to do it on a consistent level. Because nobody can just say — somebody who's in this tradition suddenly you can do that. And I think David Murray respects that. You can't make him play a Chinese melody like a Chinese person. But what I did do was take the Chinese melody and let him hear, by the Chinese musicians, but then play it the way he does, which is, on the "Butterfly Lover" song he treats it almost like a Cannonball Adderley fifties funk, that Gospel funk.

MR: The soul jazz thing, yeah.

JJ: And so he tears it up. And the Chinese musicians love it. Now that's the Chinese musicians in the United States, and possibly the young Chinese musicians. But if you brought it over to China, which we did, in Beijing, the Beijing International Jazz Festival in 1997, they're so used to hearing the "Butterfly Lover" song the way it's performed by the classical orchestra, violin concerto, that was composed by Liang Shanbo and Zhu Yingtai in 1958, that they just can't accept it. In fact they don't even want to see Chinese instruments in jazz. They want to see authentic jazz, see. And so right now in this time, 2003, they're not ready for what I'm offering.

MR: That's really interesting. If I was to go to Beijing and turn on the most popular radio station, can you describe what I'm likely to hear?

JJ: I can't answer that.

MR: Okay. I just wondered if they have embraced American pop.

JJ: Oh. I can only tell you that when I was — I'm trying to remember was it '97? Because I haven't been there since 1999 and that was Hong Kong. But was it '97 that the son of one of the Beijing opera musicians said, "Yeah they're getting into rap but it's M.C. Hammer." So they were behind. But I'm sure that's certainly changed. But when I was in the stores you saw a lot of was it Michael Jordan and Allen Iverson paraphernalia and then you saw Michael Jackson and Michael Bolton and I think Kenny G. So in Hong Kong though, it's highly sophisticated. I saw David Murray recordings, Henry Threadgill recordings, and actually my recordings.

MR: That's good. I was going to ask about that. I mean I know you've been involved in creating your own record label with a partner and I assume it's kind of hard work?

JJ: Well I don't run the record company. I co-founded the record company and it gave an opportunity for many Asian American artists to self produce a recording and try to use it to leverage themselves to create more work opportunities. But it's changed where, I mean now in Chicago somebody else is handling the business. We have a catalogue I think of over 60 recordings, maybe 70 by now. But I co-founded it. So my relationship with the record company was after Soul Note, their recording projects diminished and I stopped recording with them in '95. Not because I didn't want to but it was so hard for them to produce recordings, that I return to Asian Improv simply because they offered three recording projects to me. And part of it was developing a five-year plan and strategy with me. So at a meeting with Francis Wong we discussed some of the project ideas. And in 1990 I did a project with Max Roach, a collaboration. It was called "Senses, Rainbow Anthems." It was an attempt to redefine the concept of the National Anthem. So we did it with Max Roach and Sonia Sanchez the poet, Victor Hernandez Cruz, a poet from Puerto Rico, John Santos, a percussionist from the San Francisco Bay area, and Genny Lim, a poet playwright from San Francisco, with a multicultural ensemble. So I developed a

great relationship with Max Roach at that time and he just he got the MacArthur and so it was great developing that relationship. But I hadn't done anything with him, I think it was, yeah it was seven or eight years. And so here was an opportunity, would you like to record with Max Roach. I said well I'll see what Max has to say. So I'm thinking well okay maybe in three or five years I'll be able to raise the money and be able to do that. And when I told Max in May 1998, I was in New York with James Newton doing research on Paul Robeson, he said, "I'm ready, let's do it now, let's do it next month." I said bububu — but Max, how am I going to raise the money? And the executive producer, Steve Phillips, said he really highly respects Max Roach and he said well yeah let's do it. And we did it and I mean it's just one of those mad scrambles, and I'm just blessed with the opportunity. Because we wanted to try to go China soon after that but unfortunately we were unable to do that. But the first project which was originally going to be with David Murray and then I had to bump that and then David shifted his schedule to accommodate me and it was — I could try to explain, you know Max is older, I've got to do it now and anyway, I made amends by scrambling to be able to do it three months after. And so now we came out with this recording "River of Life" five years later.

MR: Wow. When people ask you what you do, if they don't know you too well, what do you say?

JJ: Well I say I'm an artist. And an artist has multiple roles. I'm a composer, a pianist, artistic director of ensembles, I'm also a spokesperson, an educator, I do intellectual work, that is, the arts advocacy work. Recently I served on the Arts Advisory Committee for the Ford Foundation which is going to launch a national initiative to provide direct support to artists. And this is one of the changing trends that I'm seeing in foundations and national service organizations. Because I was a recipient of a three-year residency program of Meet the Composer. That's a national service organization in New York which fosters the creation, performance, production and dissemination of new work by living American composers. So that's their mission statement. And what they did is they provided direct support to me. Because traditionally they used to provide direct support to an arts organization. And there was always problems. So that was, to me, an expression of validation of the artist. And then there's Creative Capital Foundation which has provided direct support in a very strategic way — you know one year, two year, three year — and they're part of a process where they do not want to be recognized as a funder but a partner. They want to have ownership in the work, but not ownership in sort of a corporate, capitalistic way, but in really — I mean Creative Capital is run by people who are in the arts world. So sometimes there's a knee jerk reaction from other artists who are kind of disconnected from them, they just think oh your arts project is going to be co-opted. So I mean as an artist I don't think of myself as like a musician — or no, I think of

myself as a musician but I don't think of myself as somebody who does gigs. I mean most of what I do is the music of Jon Jang or the music of Jon Jang with the music of David Murray or the music of Max Roach. So I mean Max Roach is one of the greatest artists of the twentieth century.

MR: As a parent, you are a parent and have a family, you have realistic living expenses and so forth, which part of your role as an artist helps you survive the most?

JJ: Well it's different every year. In May, I think it was a May issue of *Time* magazine there was a list of occupations that had wage slashes and the top one was I think auctioneers. I think it was something like over 90 thousand to 45 thousand. And composers were the second, somewhere around 90 thousand to 45 thousand. So I mean yeah, this year it's really slow. But you know in some ways artists, we're able to deal with the fluidity of the economy. Especially people like me who improvise. I mean you improvise in the music but you have to improvise and sort of have a creative, well be creative and sophisticated to be able to support your work and your family. So some of it is looking, see I spoke about the non-profit arts world. But some of it is looking at market hybridity and trying to, you know like for example the work "A Musical Tribute to Paul Robeson: When Sorrow Turns to Joy" that James Newton and I composed, the story of Paul Robeson and his contributions that we discovered could be made into curriculum materials for the high schools, for colleges. So ideas like that. And I think that for us, our strength, artists as catalysts, is that we can incubate like new work and ideas. And that's not only, well that's a powerful tool in these artists-in-residency. But that's something that's translatable in the business world when they incubate ideas and so forth. A model of that which I think I read it was incorporated, they had an interview with Robert Redford and it was a great interview where he described the incubator process and how that, you know what we're faced in this country is an idea drought and how Sundance played an important role in creating this process, this laboratory, into developing these independent films which also created, I mean aside from it being important values to our country, and I guess that's the other part that Robert Redford said about economic development. He's not only concerned about revenue, which they were successful at, but the quality of revenue. So I think that's what we bring to this table is that when we invest in something like the music that we're creating and there should be an awareness of the quality of the revenue. I mean in other words this non-profit arts organization that I co-founded, we share a building with an organization called Justice Matters, which is not an arts organization. But they support us, providing us technical assistance, web support and space, because their clients see that they're not about making money. That they are part of something with people that are compassionate and it's not all about money but about art and creating a societal change. And so that's what, that's why we have to be proactive. Because a lot of times

what's a weakness in arts advocacy — because in some ways it's been set up to be an entitlement program. And we're just learning I think artists, arts makers, arts administrators, foundations and funders are just beginning to learn how do we articulate ourselves to be able to win people over, the public opinion. So and one way is how arts does, for every dollar that's put in the arts, eight dollars is developed out of that. And arts helps build tourism, it creates other jobs with restaurants, hotels, taxicab drivers and so forth. So that's why I think the other part of Jon Jang is that we have to look at our art in relationship to our life and our public and our communities. And the other part of it is that I'm part of some important physical and historical communities in San Francisco Chinatown, in Japantown, and Oakland Chinatown. And those are very important experiences because we bring young people to these places so that they're not like isolated in say white suburbs and you know all the whole world is that block. And it's not just I think Chinese-Americans, but also other people. Because that's part of I mean Chinese-American and Japanese-American history is part of American history. So then for people who are not of those nationalities I think that's important for them to know, for them to understand their experiences as Americans.

MR: Does having — speaking of young people — does having children change your work at all?

JJ: Well it's like Charles Mingus said, "Let my children hear music." And I just want to — well not only that but one of my friends and I guess I could say he was a mentor, maybe more of a symbolic mentor, was the late Horace Tapscott, who was the leader of the Pan African Peoples Arkestra in Los Angeles. Are you familiar with him?

MR: Um hum.

JJ: You know I mean he was like a cultural warrior and a well loved person and he passed away in February 1999. But he said you know art should be contributive. Not competitive. And he stayed in Los Angeles in the hood and nurtured a lot of people. And he didn't leave the area to go to New York to become successful. And so, and he was around the time with like the Watts riots and you'd bring music on a flatbed truck, I mean sort of a jazz mobile. I'm not quite sure of the history. I mean I'm also kind of tired so it's probably hard for me to speak of that. Actually there's a book that even mentions me that's by Steven Isor called *Songs of the Unsung: the Musical Journey of Horace Tapscott*. It's very inspiring. But family is important. I mean the artists that I'm around, that's very important tradition and legacy. Because it's not just about the artist, just the artist themselves, but these are — my experiences are important to give to my child because it gives my 8-year-old daughter something that's very special.

MR: What's the effect of 80 cable channels, and constant music everywhere you go, on people's attention span?

JJ: Boy. I wonder if the music's going to sound like that. I mean like how Duke Ellington and Charles Mingus, you know they would change from meter to meter and tempo modulations, it would sound like, on what 78 or 156 on a turntable? You just speed it up. God I don't know how that would — because you know in our social action now people are driving faster, spaces are becoming tighter.

MR: I guess I was just wondering, the work you do, to me, requires a fairly sophisticated listening audience. And I worry that we still have that as time goes by.

JJ: Well your concern is something that I have seriously considered. And that's why I think I do have to have multiple ways to, like the other question to survive. And I don't think I could just survive just doing that kind of music. But that doesn't mean that I'm going to — I mean there's other ways to see Jon Jang because I'm very versatile. And one of the weaknesses I've had over the years is because I've had to create all these ambitious projects with such great artists that my voice as a pianist has been suppressed. Because I can perform in a lot of kind of situations because I've had diverse experiences. So Billy Taylor, I've collaborated with him at the Asia Society of New York in 1995 with taiko performer Kenny Endo from Hawaii, and we did part of a series called "Crossovers." And it was collaborations with Asian traditional music and jazz. And Dr. Taylor told me that, "You know Jon you have some important stories to tell." And I thought about it and I said yeah but my present projects, which are really not tourable. I mean the Jon Jang sextet, that with Billy Hart, David Murray and James Newton, six great artists, and then I'm not doing jazz repertory music, and they're all busy. It's not practical. So now I'm kind of looking at well yeah Billy Taylor has, I'm not saying that I will do what Billy Taylor does, but maybe I need to have like a trio that features my voice as a pianist and then I could tell stories like the way Dr. Taylor does. Because you see that there is no Chinese traditional music. Because actually there's been problems working with Chinese traditional musicians because if they're unable to perform with you because they have other commitments then where do you go to get Chinese traditional musicians? And then if you do find them, they're not used to performing in that context. So I think I've done some important work that hasn't been done but in terms of it having an impact — well in terms of like audiences it's limited. I mean you can look back and say yeah this is important in terms of posterity, but it's like there's certain survival — what about me trying to sustain that. And also I think some of these projects, there isn't an organic — I mean the residencies have been important in terms of incubating so that great — but then you don't get to that level where if you're performing every night or on a consistent level at least once every two weeks with those ensembles or new works, then you can't take that music to another level.

MR: Would you feel comfortable for instance trying to book a trio gig at, is it Yoshi's in Oakland? Is that the jazz club there?

JJ: Yeah, I mean I've performed there as a sextet. And actually I did do a trio, but I don't think I had my concept of the kind of music I was going to do. It hadn't developed. It hadn't emerged. But so I have to think about that. And if I wanted to be in the jazz market I probably would have to do standard repertory. I don't know if I would do that. I mean I did perform an Ellington program with "Clothed Woman" and some works that are not part of what I call quote unquote Ellington standards, but some of the lesser known works that are incredible works themselves that I like, I enjoy it. But I'm not sure if I would want to tour with it or commit to that. So if you want to be part of the jazz market you have to do that kind of — like presenters, especially in a period where they're uncomfortable, they're worried about the box office and the revenues and particularly in this economy, they want something that's familiar, and they know people are going to come. If you keep changing your face, like well what is Jon Jang doing now, it's a chameleon, then they feel very uncomfortable. "Oh I thought I saw you do that last year and now you're doing this."

MR: How am I going to book that and bill that.

JJ: And then sometimes in the jazz market they want to hear you perform. It's not — they don't want to hear a new work. They want to hear somebody that can play, for whatever reason. They want to hear the experience of this performer or that song, like it was on the recording.

MR: They want to hear "Take the A String." That's part of an inside joke that no-one knows what we're talking about but it was a good joke on your part actually. You know you said something interesting. A student apparently had asked you about the state or the future of jazz. And you were saying you think there's a disconnect between the current young generation and what has come before. Did I say that right?

JJ: Yeah I think that, I don't think I'm the best person to answer that because I'm from San Francisco, I'm not part of like the New York scene. So in some ways it might come off kind of detached. But my initial feelings and it's probably not even well thought out, is that David Murray is like, I think represents that last generation, the eighties. And I just remember one year when, I think it was 1990 or maybe it was the late eighties, there was a young saxophonist, Christopher Holliday, and he was sort of — maybe Jackie McLean, I don't know if he was a mentor or a clone — but here's a young kid that the music industry — I shouldn't say young kid, he was a young adult — that the music industry chose to record and here's Clifford Jordan who hadn't had a recording date. So he's like a generation, maybe one or two generations, I can't even think of what the age difference with David Murray, and I always found that David Murray connected with so many

musicians like I sat in his big band one time and they had Sunny Murray and it was a great, great experience with Butch Morris doing conduction. And so he has these ties. But I don't know if there is that kind of mentor relationship now.

MR: Well we certainly have the universities to teach jazz. Maybe the mentor thing has been replaced by that, by all the programs.

JJ: Well it's kind of like I use the analogy of a basketball team. If you have a veteran team, and now this is before they've even played a game, but like the Los Angeles Lakers, they're champions because they have veterans and young players. Now they have a 40-year-old, Malone, they've got 35-year-old Payton, a 30-year-old Shaquille O'Neall, 25-year-old Kobe Bryant. I mean of course they're Hall of Famers so you can't really use the age as a factor, you have to factor in that variable. But you have veterans and young players. If you just have young players then you've got the Los Angeles Clippers. So see I'm trying to recall like I don't know the full story about that but I heard that Wynton Marsalis had like older musicians in the Lincoln Jazz Center Orchestra. I think — was Roland Hanna — anyway he had older musicians and then I heard all of a sudden they were gone and he just had musicians that were, I don't know 35 or 30 and younger. And so I thought that was a loss for Wynton's jazz orchestra. Because that could have been a very beneficial experience for both the older musicians and the younger musicians.

MR: Uh, just to wrap up, it's September '03 as we're talking and how do you feel about the state of the country?

JJ: Oh well it's like Max Roach he told me he said I can't save the world. I mean he's lived such a full life and you kind of see the roller coaster and the changing trends. I don't know you know part of it is I guess being a Christian you have faith. And sometimes, well I guess the recording that David Murray and I did called "River of Life" and that's from Revelations I think it's 21 or 22. And I think let's see if I can recall the scriptures, it says, "Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, as clear as crystal, flowing down from the throne of God and it's Lamb, down the middle of the great street and its city, yielding fruit for every month, bearing twelve crops of fruit. And the leaves of the nation will — the healing will heal the nations. I think that's one of the NIV version then there's a King James which is different. But that scripture was offered to me by my pastor, who is a woman, and she delivered that after 9/11. So there is a meaning that God's love is always abundant. And it's like — it's like a river but not like a literate river. There's no such river that exists hydrologically speaking on the planet, but it's always flowing. So that gives me faith and I mean people like Thomas Dorsey, stories like him, the creation of "Take my Hand Precious Lord." I mean in 1932 his wife and first born died and maybe I'm a little over-exaggerating but he was going to like give up music or maybe he was just going to play the blues. And then he saw this image of a rock

with I think water or tears flowing down. It's just like the "River of Life" on the piano. I think he was trying to play some hymn, "Peace in the Valley" or something. I don't remember. But all of a sudden this peace blossom. Take my hand precious Lord. And it's just such a moving piece because it's like being in sea where there's calmness and then there's that storm and it hits that high pitch. And I forgot where I heard Marion Williams, when I used to perform in an African-American church that was a song that was sung and tears were streaming down people's faces. So that gives me faith. And Thomas Dorsey had a lot of struggle in his life getting his music accepted in the churches because of what he was trying to do. So in terms of me trying to do my music or us providing an alternative vision, we have to look at that. And we even have to look at the whole contributions of African-American people. They were brought over here as slaves unwillingly and that they built this country. W.E.B. DuBois said that, with their brawn and sweat. But they also brought us their songs, and that's what's really, I mean their spirituals. Boy that's — that's I think, helped me — look at my people — or I should say our people — but my cultural identity specifically with Chinese people, what they brought here and how can I help contribute to that. And the problem is I think, maybe it's different because for where we are at, Chinese-Americans, in our place in history in American in terms of art it's very different. Because we have communities. We don't have let's say a black nation. And also in other words what I'm trying to say is I don't want to compare what I'm trying to do with all those great creators. Because I understand well I won't say limitations but the fact that I'm an individual who's been disconnected from my roots for a long period of time, that this is what my reality is and this is how my music is going to be. And I can't make it, on a certain level, I don't mean artistic level, but the level that, I can't artificially create a level that could be measured by any kind of standards whether European or African-American. I can only measure it by my own level and by just trying to raise it to the highest artistic level possible.

MR: You're creating your own level.

JJ: Well I'm trying to but then you can't just listen to yourself either. Because then you're not really raising the level. That's why you have to always measure your music by what these great artists did and then try to — not be like them — well not be like them — be like them in the way of just being, just creating and committing to do that, and not being distracted by all these other things, with things that go on in the world. Maybe that's the inference of your question about what do you think about the world now, is that yeah for artists, okay maybe I can end with like a quote that Paul Robeson said. A great culture — or he said — a great civilization is measured by its culture, not by its might. And so that's why for us as artists we have to continue to create an alternative to war and violence and what we're doing is creating values that we want to bring people back to. We don't want

to invent new ways to kill people. And not only costly ways, and I don't mean economically, but cost in terms of lives.

MR: Well those are wonderful sentiments.

JJ: But what does that have to do with the jazz archive? I don't know.

MR I think it's a worthy contribution.

JJ: Well thank you.

MR: It's what I wanted to hear from you in a sense, that I don't have from anybody else. All right? Thank you for your time.

JJ: Thank you very much, Monk.